↘ THE FOREST (CONSERVATION) AMENDMENT ACT, 2023
Proposes to exempt certain categories of lands from the purview of the Act, but "only to fast-track projects of national importance"

↘ THE INDIAN INSTITUTES OF MANAGEMENT (AMENDMENT) ACT, 2023
Seeks to increase government control over IIMs. The board of governors of IIMs will have to obtain the prior approval of the Visitor—the President of India—before appointing a director

↘ THE ANUSANDHAN NATIONAL RESEARCH FOUNDATION ACT, 2023
Seeks to establish a Rs 50,000-crore fund to 'seed, grow and promote' research and development in India's educational/research institutes

↘ THE CINEMATOGRAPH (AMENDMENT) ACT, 2023
Seeks to deter film piracy by imposing penalties on individuals involved in unauthorised audio-visual recording and distribution of copyrighted content

On August 4, the Supreme Court stayed the conviction, paving the way for his reinstatement.

All the decibels, of course, were soon being taken up by the no-confidence motion against Prime Minister Narendra Modi's government, only the second such since it came to power in 2014. Though the Opposition clearly did not have the numbers, the motion was resorted to presumably to force Modi to speak on the Manipur violence. The government, though ready to discuss the subject, had been unwilling to yield on a statement by the PM. The schism was such that walkouts and boycotts became the predominant flavour. Which was to have fateful consequences, because some of the contentious bills had an easy passage—without a debate. On August 2, Opposition MPs in the Rajya Sabha staged a walkout after deputy chairman Harivansh Narayan Singh denied them an opportunity to speak on violent incidents across the country, including in BJP-ruled Manipur and Haryana. In the wake of that display of righteous indignation, the Forest (Conservation) Amendment Bill and the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2023, quietly became law.

One bill that did not receive the blessing of silence was the Government of National Capital Territory of Delhi (Amendment) Act, 2023. Seen as the BJP-led Centre's coup de grace in a long battle against Arvind Kejriwal's Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), the Act cedes partial administrative and political control over Delhi to the Centre. The bill was also a test case for Opposition unity: the Congress had taken around two months to lend its voice against it, a delay that had seen Kejriwal threaten to walk out of the 'INDIA' bloc. Finally, it was Congress leaders and legal luminaries Abhishek Manu Singhvi and P. Chidambaram who presented the strongest arguments against the bill.

Even amidst all the sloganeering, one moment of parliamentary civility stood out. Defence minister Rajnath Singh was speaking in the Lok Sabha on the Inter-Services Organisations (Command, Control and Discipline) Bill, 2023, when Opposition MPs stormed the well, raising slogans on the Manipur issue. The veteran leader didn't try to outshout the MPs, merely walked across to the backbenches and continued speaking. The bill eventually passed without much rancour. An innocuous presence amidst others that may one day elicit the description: 'the monsoon session after which India won't be the same'. ■

NUH/BULLDOZER ACTION

THE LAW ISN'T FOR BREAKING

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

A stern judicial veto from the Punjab & Haryana High Court has put a question mark on the legality of punitive demolitions of homes and other structures by bulldozers. The controversial action—pioneered as a hardline law and order measure by Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi Adityanath and taken up with enthusiasm by a series of his compeers—was most recently on view in Nuh, the riot-torn district in south Haryana. On August 7, a suo motu action by the division bench of Justice G.S. Sandhawalia and Justice Harpreet Kaur Jeewan put the brakes on bulldozers set rolling by the Manohar Lal Khattar regime against those seen as having participated in the violence. But by then, the deed was done—over four days, the local agencies had already demolished about 350 shanties and 50 structures, including homes, shops and commercial spaces on the pretext of clearing encroachments on government land. Those targeted were primarily Muslim.

As the bulldozers started to move, Haryana home minister and BJP leader Anil Vij had came out and said it was part of the "*ilaaj*" as the government investigated the communal violence. The court took note of this while making its comments: "The issue also arises whether the buildings belonging to a particular community are being brought down under the guise of a law and order problem...and an exercise of ethnic cleansing is being conducted by the state."

Haryana was stunned on July 31 when violence broke out during a Hindu religious procession in Nuh, the state's only Muslim-majority district. It didn't help that the right-wing Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP), many of its members "bearing swords and sticks", was an ac-